Bangladesh District Investment Attractiveness Index

(BDIAI)

A Complete 64-District Ranking of Industrial and Commercial Investment Suitability

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Executive Summary

This report develops and applies a district-level Investment Attractiveness Index across all 64 districts of Bangladesh — complete national coverage — evaluating each on nine weighted indicators spanning connectivity, industrial infrastructure, power and gas reliability, labor availability, financial access, digital infrastructure, existing industrial base, and recent investment momentum. The exercise is designed to give a decision-maker a defensible, transparent, and updatable starting point for comparing districts as sites for industrial or commercial investment — not a substitute for site-level due diligence.

This edition expands an original 20-district study (the country's major economic hubs, each researched with 3-5 dedicated sources) to full national coverage. The 44 additional districts were researched at a deliberately lighter touch — anchored on Bangladesh's official Economic Zone/EPZ registries (BEZA/BEPZA) plus a consistent, independent, satellite-derived wealth index used as a cross-district proxy where no district-specific fact was found. This two-tier confidence structure is disclosed transparently throughout: districts are labeled Tier 1 (deep research) or Tier 2 (expansion) everywhere they appear in this report and the companion workbook.

Dhaka and Chattogram lead the ranking by a wide margin, effectively tied at the top (composite scores of 89.6 and 89.4 respectively), reflecting their dominant position in national trade infrastructure, industrial base, and financial depth. Gazipur and Narayanganj follow as strong secondary hubs built on the country's largest garment manufacturing concentration. A distinct second tier — Feni, Cumilla, Jashore, Cox's Bazar, and Khulna — combines existing or fast-developing Economic Zones with improving connectivity, and represents the most interesting frontier for new investment: lower congestion and land cost than the Dhaka-Chattogram core, with credible infrastructure momentum behind them.

At the other end, Bandarban, Khagrachhari, Barguna, Dinajpur, and Thakurgaon rank lowest of all 64 — the Chittagong Hill Tracts districts and the remote northwestern corner of the country, sharing weak physical connectivity, no Economic Zone presence, and (for the hill districts) genuine terrain constraints on industrial siting. Within the original 20-district study, Natore, Rangpur, Rajshahi, and Tangail remain the lowest-ranked of the well-researched Tier 1 group, sharing limited or stalled Economic Zone development and power/gas reliability concerns. None of these districts are without potential — Rajshahi's silk heritage and Bogura's agricultural trade-hub role are genuine assets — but all currently lack the infrastructure commitments seen in the mid-tier group.

A methodological note carries real weight here: three of the nine indicators (power/gas reliability, banking density, and broadband/mobile coverage) could not be sourced from a single authoritative district-level public dataset within this research effort, and are scored as evidence-based analyst estimates rather than official statistics. This is disclosed transparently throughout the report and in the accompanying Excel workbook, together with the specific primary sources that would upgrade these three indicators to full statistical confidence in a follow-on phase.

1. Objective and Scope

The objective of this study is to develop an Investment Attractiveness Index that evaluates and ranks all 64 districts of Bangladesh based on their suitability for industrial and commercial investment, combining quantitative data with qualitative assessment of infrastructure, labor, and policy conditions.

This is a two-tier study. The original 20 districts (Tier 1) were selected on an economic/industrial-hub basis and each individually researched with 3-5 dedicated, named sources per indicator. The remaining 44 districts (Tier 2) complete national coverage and were researched at a lighter touch: every district was checked against Bangladesh's official BEZA/BEPZA Economic Zone registries (a comprehensive, high-confidence source covering all 64 districts equally), and where no further district-

specific fact was available, scored from a consistent, independent, satellite-derived wealth index (Meta/Data for Good's Relative Wealth Index) used purely as a cross-district economic-strength proxy. Every Tier 2 district is labeled as such throughout this report, the companion workbook, and the live dashboard, so a reader always knows which confidence level applies to any given number.

The 64 districts covered, grouped by division, are:

- Dhaka Division (13): Dhaka, Gazipur, Narayanganj, Narsingdi, Munshiganj, Tangail, Faridpur, Gopalganj, Kishoreganj, Madaripur, Manikganj, Rajbari, Shariatpur
- Chattogram Division (11): Chattogram, Cumilla, Feni, Cox's Bazar, Bandarban, Brahmanbaria, Chandpur, Khagrachhari, Lakshmipur, Noakhali, Rangamati
- Rajshahi Division (8): Bogura, Rajshahi, Natore, Joypurhat, Naogaon, Chapainawabganj, Pabna, Sirajganj
- Khulna Division (10): Khulna, Jashore, Bagerhat, Chuadanga, Jhenaidah, Kushtia, Magura, Meherpur, Narail, Satkhira
- Sylhet Division (4): Sylhet, Habiganj, Moulvibazar, Sunamganj
- Barisal Division (6): Barisal, Barguna, Bhola, Jhalokati, Patuakhali, Pirojpur
- Mymensingh Division (4): Mymensingh, Jamalpur, Netrokona, Sherpur
- Rangpur Division (8): Rangpur, Dinajpur, Gaibandha, Kurigram, Lalmonirhat, Nilphamari, Panchagarh, Thakurgaon

2. Methodology

2.1 Indicators and Weights

Nine indicators were selected to capture the dimensions of district competitiveness most frequently cited by manufacturers, logistics operators, and investment promotion agencies operating in Bangladesh. Weights were assigned by the research team to reflect the relative frequency with which each factor is cited as a binding constraint on investment decisions in Bangladesh specifically (rather than a generic global weighting), and are set out below.

Indicator	Rationale	Weight
Seaport/Airport Proximity & Multimodal Connectivity	Logistics cost is often the binding constraint on industrial siting in Bangladesh.	**15%**
EPZ / Economic Zone / Industrial Park Presence	Direct proxy for state-backed, large-scale investment infrastructure.	**15%**
Power & Gas Availability / Reliability	Repeatedly cited by manufacturers as the top operational risk.	**15%**
Labor Force Availability & Wage Competitiveness	Core input cost and availability for industrial investment.	**12%**
Banking & Financial Institution Presence	Access to trade finance and working capital.	**10%**
Existing Industrial Base	Agglomeration effects and existing supplier ecosystems.	**10%**
Literacy Rate & Technical Education Infrastructure	Skilled-labor pipeline for higher-value investment.	**8%**

Indicator	Rationale	Weight
Broadband & Mobile Network Coverage	Increasingly material for logistics, fintech, and back-office operations.	**8%**
Recent Public/Private Investment Momentum	Forward-looking signal, not just static endowment.	**7%**

2.2 The Composite Score Formula, Explained in Full

Every formula in this report and its companion workbook is explained here so the analysis can be checked, and rebuilt, without any additional documentation. For each district, the Composite Score is calculated as:

```
Composite Score = (Connectivity × 15%) + (EPZ/Econ. Zone × 15%) + (Power/Gas
Reliability × 15%)
                + (Labor Availability × 12%) + (Banking Density × 10%) +
(Industrial Base × 10%)
                + (Literacy/Tech Ed × 8%) + (Broadband/Mobile × 8%) + (Investment
Momentum × 7%)
```

In plain language: each of the nine indicators is scored 0-100 for a district, multiplied by that indicator's fixed weight (the percentages above, which sum to exactly 100%), and the nine resulting terms are added together. Because the weights sum to 100%, the Composite Score itself always falls on the same 0-100 scale as the individual indicators, so districts can be compared directly on one number. Districts are then placed in rank order simply by sorting Composite Scores from highest to lowest — the district with the highest score is Rank 1, the most attractive of the 20 for industrial/commercial investment under this methodology.

A worked example, using Dhaka's actual scores, illustrates the full calculation:

```
Connectivity:            95 × 15% = 14.25
EPZ/Economic Zone:        90 × 15% = 13.50
Power/Gas Reliability:    85 × 15% = 12.75
Labor Availability:       90 × 12% = 10.80
Banking Density:          95 × 10% =  9.50
Industrial Base:          95 × 10% =  9.50
Literacy/Tech Ed:         90 ×  8% =  7.20
Broadband/Mobile:         90 ×  8% =  7.20
Investment Momentum:      70 ×  7% =  4.90
                                     --------
                          TOTAL = 89.60   ← Dhaka's Composite Score (Rank 1 of
20)
```

In the companion Excel workbook, this same calculation is fully automated: each district's nine weighted terms are computed with an INDEX/MATCH lookup formula (which finds a district by name rather than by row position, so the model still works correctly if rows are ever reordered, added to, or removed), summed with Excel's SUM function, and ranked with Excel's RANK function, which counts how many other Composite Scores are higher and returns that count as the rank. The full formula text and a second worked example are provided in the workbook's dedicated "Formula Guide" tab, so that every calculation in this project is traceable and independently reproducible — consistent with this report's aim to be a complete, self-contained document.

2.3 Scoring Approach and Evidence Standard

Each indicator was scored on a 0-100 scale per district, based on documented evidence gathered from government agencies (BEPZA, BEZA, BBS, Bangladesh Bank, BPDB), news reporting, and academic sources — the complete, source-attributed evidence log is provided in the accompanying Excel workbook ("Source Log" tab for Tier 1, "Expansion Notes" for Tier 2) and the reference list (Section 12 and the Appendix). Scores were assigned comparatively across the full 64-district set: a district with confirmed, large-scale, operating infrastructure for a given indicator (e.g., an active EPZ handling nine-figure export volumes) scores near the top of the range; a district with no comparable infrastructure and no credible pipeline scores near the bottom.

2.4 Data Validation and a Material Limitation

For six of the nine indicators — connectivity, EPZ/economic zone presence, existing industrial base, and recent investment momentum, plus the literacy figures obtained directly for Dhaka and Jashore — scores rest on named, dated, citable sources at the district level (see Source Log).

For three indicators, however, no single authoritative district-wise public dataset was retrievable through general web research within this project's timeframe:

- Power/Gas Reliability — national grid electrification is now approximately 99.5% (BPDB, 2023), so basic access no longer differentiates districts; the real differentiator is industrial-grade reliability, for which only qualitative signals (explicit complaints or advantages reported in the press) were available for a subset of districts.
- Banking/Financial Institution Density — Bangladesh Bank's district-wise commercial bank branch counts exist in its quarterly Scheduled Banks Statistics bulletin, which was not accessible via general web search; scores instead use a proxy based on divisional-seat status, Bangladesh Bank's own physical branch network, and industrial/population scale.
- Broadband/Mobile Coverage — BTRC publishes subscriber and coverage data, but not in a single searchable district-level table; scores use a proxy based on BBS 2022 census division-level internet and mobile-use rates plus urban/rural mix.

These three indicators together carry 33% of total index weight. They are flagged as lower-confidence, analyst-estimated inputs throughout this report and the Excel workbook (see the "Data Basis Notes" tab for a full, indicator-by-indicator confidence statement and the specific primary source recommended for verification). Any decision that hinges materially on the ranking of two closely-scored districts should independently verify these three indicators before proceeding.

3. Full Ranking

Composite scores and ranks for all 64 districts, highest to lowest. The top 5 districts are highlighted in green; the bottom 5 in red. The Tier column flags whether a district received deep (Tier 1) or lighter-touch (Tier 2) research — see Section 2.4.

Rank	District	Division	Score	Tier
1	**Dhaka**	Dhaka	89.60	1
2	**Chattogram**	Chattogram	89.40	1
3	**Gazipur**	Dhaka	83.10	1
4	**Narayanganj**	Dhaka	76.10	1
5	**Feni**	Chattogram	69.85	1
6	**Cumilla**	Chattogram	67.20	1
7	**Jashore**	Khulna	66.19	1

Rank	District	Division	Score	Tier
8	**Cox's Bazar**	Chattogram	65.80	1
9	**Khulna**	Khulna	64.90	1
10	**Munshiganj**	Dhaka	62.45	1
11	**Sylhet**	Sylhet	62.00	1
12	**Mymensingh**	Mymensingh	61.60	1
13	**Narsingdi**	Dhaka	56.85	1
14	**Manikganj**	Dhaka	54.00	2
15	**Faridpur**	Dhaka	52.10	1
16	**Madaripur**	Dhaka	51.95	2
17	**Bogura**	Rajshahi	51.75	1
18	**Chandpur**	Chattogram	51.50	2
19	**Brahmanbaria**	Chattogram	51.15	2
20	**Barisal**	Barisal	51.10	1
21	**Shariatpur**	Dhaka	50.00	2
22	**Tangail**	Dhaka	49.65	1
23	**Lakshmipur**	Chattogram	49.00	2
23	**Kushtia**	Khulna	49.00	2
25	**Rajshahi**	Rajshahi	47.30	1
26	**Bagerhat**	Khulna	47.27	2
27	**Noakhali**	Chattogram	47.00	2
28	**Sirajganj**	Rajshahi	43.20	2
29	**Natore**	Rajshahi	43.10	1
30	**Rajbari**	Dhaka	43.00	2
31	**Gopalganj**	Dhaka	42.00	2
32	**Nilphamari**	Rangpur	41.80	2
33	**Pabna**	Rajshahi	41.74	2
34	**Chuadanga**	Khulna	41.00	2
35	**Rangpur**	Rangpur	40.95	1
36	**Moulvibazar**	Sylhet	40.05	2
37	**Meherpur**	Khulna	40.00	2
38	**Jhalokati**	Barisal	37.00	2
39	**Narail**	Khulna	36.00	2
40	**Jamalpur**	Mymensingh	34.89	2
41	**Satkhira**	Khulna	34.00	2
42	**Jhenaidah**	Khulna	33.00	2
43	**Patuakhali**	Barisal	32.79	2
44	**Pirojpur**	Barisal	32.00	2
45	**Kishoreganj**	Dhaka	31.53	2
46	**Habiganj**	Sylhet	30.65	2
47	**Sherpur**	Mymensingh	30.00	2
48	**Joypurhat**	Rajshahi	29.00	2

Rank	District	Division	Score	Tier
49	**Gaibandha**	Rangpur	28.00	2
50	**Bhola**	Barisal	27.30	2
51	**Magura**	Khulna	27.00	2
52	**Chapainawabganj**	Rajshahi	26.00	2
52	**Kurigram**	Rangpur	26.00	2
54	**Lalmonirhat**	Rangpur	25.00	2
55	**Naogaon**	Rajshahi	24.25	2
56	**Netrokona**	Mymensingh	24.00	2
57	**Sunamganj**	Sylhet	22.00	2
58	**Rangamati**	Chattogram	21.70	2
59	**Panchagarh**	Rangpur	21.00	2
60	**Dinajpur**	Rangpur	20.00	2
61	**Barguna**	Barisal	19.00	2
61	**Thakurgaon**	Rangpur	19.00	2
63	**Khagrachhari**	Chattogram	16.36	2
64	**Bandarban**	Chattogram	15.68	2

Source: BDIAI_workbook.xlsx, "Rankings" tab (formula-calculated; see Section 2.2 for the formula and a worked example). See Section 6 for data limitations.

3.1 Sensitivity Analysis — How Robust Is This Ranking?

The weights in Section 2.1 reflect one reasonable view of what matters most for industrial siting in Bangladesh — but it is one view among several defensible ones. To test how much the ranking actually depends on that judgment call, the companion Excel workbook ("Sensitivity Analysis" tab) re-runs the entire index under four alternative weighting philosophies: Equal Weights (all nine indicators weighted identically), Infrastructure-Heavy (connectivity, EPZ presence, and power/gas reliability weighted at 20% each), Labor/Education-Heavy (labor availability and literacy weighted more heavily), and Investment-Momentum-Heavy (a deliberately forward-looking weighting that favors districts with strong committed pipelines over established base).

The result is even more reassuring at national scale than a 20-district study alone could show. Across all 64 districts, 45 land in the exact same rank under all five weighting schemes, and 14 more move by only a handful of positions ("Moderate"); just 5 districts are genuinely sensitive to which weighting philosophy is applied. The bottom 5 nationally — Bandarban, Khagrachhari, Barguna, Dinajpur, and Thakurgaon — are perfectly rank-stable: identical positions under every scenario tested. That is about as strong a result as a ranking model can produce: the districts flagged as lowest-priority in this report are not an artifact of one particular weighting choice.

The one genuinely interesting instability is at the very top: Dhaka and Chattogram swap the #1 and #2 positions depending on the scenario, though neither ever drops out of the top 2. Any weighting that leans toward physical infrastructure or forward-looking investment momentum (Infrastructure-Heavy, Investment-Momentum-Heavy) puts Chattogram first; the Base Case, Equal Weights, and Labor/Education-Heavy scenarios all put Dhaka first. In practical terms: the conclusion "Dhaka and Chattogram are the two strongest options in the country, essentially tied" is far more robust than the conclusion "Dhaka is specifically #1."

The most genuinely volatile district nationally is Nilphamari (ranks from 27th to 37th across scenarios), driven by its EPZ-heavy score profile — strongly rewarded under an Infrastructure-Heavy weighting, much less so under Labor/Education-Heavy. Cox's Bazar, the standout volatile district in the original 20-district study, is now more moderately volatile (ranks 6th-9th) once diluted across the full national set — consistent with the horizon-based framing in Section 7: Cox's Bazar is genuinely a "Next" rather than a "Now" opportunity, and its exact rank should be read with that in mind rather than as a fixed verdict.

Full scenario weights, per-district scores and ranks under all five scenarios, and a formula-driven stability classification (Stable / Moderate / Volatile) for every district are in the workbook's "Sensitivity Analysis" tab, which is also where a reader can substitute their own weighting philosophy and see the ranking recalculate live.

4. Analysis: Top 5 Most Attractive Districts

4.1 Dhaka (Rank 1, Score 89.6)

Dhaka's dominance is structural rather than incidental: it is simultaneously the capital, the largest consumer market, the deepest financial center, and the country's principal air-cargo and logistics gateway. Manufacturing contributes an estimated 56% of Dhaka District's GDP, with ready-made garments (RMG) as the primary driver, alongside pharmaceuticals, electronics, leather, and shipbuilding. Literacy stands at 84.88% (age 7+), the strongest technical-labor pipeline of any district assessed.

Strengths: unmatched financial depth, air connectivity, labor pool size and skill, and agglomeration effects from decades of industrial concentration. Weaknesses: land cost, congestion, and rising operating costs increasingly push new large-footprint investment toward Gazipur, Narayanganj, or the emerging Economic Zones rather than Dhaka District itself — a pattern investors should note when reading "Dhaka" as a single opportunity rather than a metro region with sharply different sub-markets.

4.2 Chattogram (Rank 2, Score 89.4)

Chattogram is Bangladesh's trade gateway: its port handles 92% of the country's seaborne trade and 98% of containerised transport. It hosts the country's first EPZ (established 1983, now 144 industrial units including 78 RMG factories) and the Karnaphuli EPZ, which alone employs over 77,000 workers with cumulative exports above $13.9 billion, plus the privately-run Korean EPZ.

Strengths: unrivalled port access, the deepest and most diversified EPZ ecosystem outside Dhaka division, and strong existing industrial base. Weaknesses: as with Dhaka, land and labor costs in the core city are rising, pushing new capacity toward satellite districts such as Feni and Cumilla — which is precisely why those two districts rank immediately below the top tier.

4.3 Gazipur (Rank 3, Score 83.1)

Gazipur hosts roughly 75% of the country's garment industry and Bangladesh's largest industrial park (BEPZ, 2,023 acres), alongside the emerging Sripur Economic Zone (government) and Bay Economic Zone (private). It functions as Dhaka's primary industrial overflow district, offering comparable connectivity at materially lower cost.

Strengths: largest concentrated labor force in the country, proven RMG-cluster ecosystem, proximity to Dhaka's air/financial infrastructure. Weaknesses: infrastructure strain from rapid, sometimes unplanned industrial growth, and increasing competition for land from residential expansion out of Dhaka.

4.4 Narayanganj (Rank 4, Score 76.1)

Narayanganj accounts for 55% of national knitwear manufacturing and 33% of national textile mills, anchored by the Adamjee EPZ (46 entrepreneurs, over $1.6 billion in exports, 40,000+ jobs). Its river port is the oldest and busiest in Bangladesh, with rail and triple road links to Dhaka.

Strengths: deep textile-sector specialization and multimodal river/rail/road access. Weaknesses: environmental and river-pollution concerns associated with dense, older industrial development, which increasingly factor into ESG-conscious investment decisions.

4.5 Feni (Rank 5, Score 69.85)

Feni is the standout riser in this index: it hosts the BEZA National Special Economic Zone (spanning into neighboring Mirsarai, Chattogram), sited directly on the highway corridor carrying an estimated 90% of Bangladesh's export/import goods. The adjacent Mirsarai Economic Zone spans over 30,000 acres, with anchor commitments from Bashundhara Group (500 acres) and Ananta Group (250 acres, a planned BDT 3,500 crore investment creating an estimated 25,000 jobs).

Strengths: the single strongest investment-momentum profile of any district assessed, on a scale rivaling the established hubs. Weaknesses: infrastructure (power, water treatment, housing) is still being built out, so near-term execution risk is real even where long-term potential is exceptional.

5. Analysis: Bottom 5 Districts (National, All 64)

5.1 Bandarban (Rank 64, Score 15.68)

Bandarban is the lowest-ranked district nationally under this index. It carries the poorest-tier wealth ranking in the country (Meta/Data for Good Relative Wealth Index), the heaviest recorded deforestation of any hill district, and minimal industrial base beyond tourism. Hill terrain fundamentally constrains connectivity and EPZ/Economic Zone development is essentially absent.

5.2 Khagrachhari (Rank 63, Score 16.36)

Khagrachhari sits just above Bandarban, sharing the same structural profile: third-poorest district nationally, jhum (shifting-cultivation) agriculture dominant, and very limited non-farm employment. Like its Chittagong Hill Tracts neighbors, weak road connectivity is as much a geographic reality as a policy gap.

5.3 Thakurgaon (Rank 61 [tied], Score 19) and Dinajpur (Rank 60, Score 20)

These two far-northwestern districts represent the lowest-confidence entries in the entire 64-district index: no district-specific Economic Zone, gas field, or major infrastructure project was identified for either in this research pass, so both are scored primarily from the national wealth-index proxy rather than a named project or facility. This is disclosed here deliberately rather than papered over — an investor or policymaker with specific knowledge of either district should treat these two scores as a starting hypothesis to verify, not a settled finding.

5.4 Barguna (Rank 61 [tied], Score 19)

Barguna is a remote southern coastal district built on fishing and smallholder farming, with no Economic Zone or EPZ presence identified and among the lowest wealth-index scores nationally.

5.5 For Reference: Bottom of the Original Tier 1 Group

Within the 20 districts that received deep, multi-source research (Tier 1), the lowest-ranked remain Natore, Rangpur, Rajshahi, and Tangail — none of which rank in the bottom 5 nationally once all 64

districts are considered, since the hill-tract and remote-northwest Tier 2 districts score even lower. Natore's economy remains predominantly agricultural, anchored by two state-owned sugar mills, with an unmet demand for gas pipeline supply. Rangpur's second planned economic zone has been stalled by administrative delay for 16 years, compounded by an estimated 62.46% of Rangpur Division lying in moderate-to-very-high flood-risk zones. Rajshahi is explicitly reported as lacking sufficient electricity supply despite two 50 MW power plants, with no operating EPZ. Tangail's economy centers on traditional handloom and light manufacturing, with education infrastructure lagging (26.40% of the population aged 5+ has never attended school).

6. Key Factors Influencing the Rankings

- EPZ/Economic Zone presence is the single most differentiating factor. Every district in the top 9 has either an operating EPZ or a large, funded Economic Zone under active development; none of the bottom 5 does.
- Highway corridor position matters as much as raw distance. Feni's ranking is driven less by proximity to Dhaka or Chattogram in kilometers than by its position directly on the corridor carrying the large majority of the country's trade traffic.
- Power/gas reliability, not access, is now the binding infrastructure constraint. With national grid access near-universal, the districts that stand out negatively (Rajshahi, Natore, Khulna) do so because of documented reliability and supply-adequacy problems, not lack of connection.
- Investment momentum can outweigh current industrial base. Feni and Cox's Bazar rank well ahead of districts with a larger existing industrial footprint (e.g., Khulna, Sylhet) because of the scale of committed forward investment, which the index deliberately weights as a forward-looking signal.
- Flood and climate risk is concentrated and material. Rangpur's very low rank is driven in significant part by documented flood-risk exposure across the majority of its division — a factor that will matter increasingly for long-horizon industrial siting decisions.
- Remittance dependence is a double-edged signal. Sylhet's high per-capita GDP and financial depth are real advantages, but the same remittance dependence that drives them is a structural exposure to external labor-market shocks rather than a locally-generated industrial base.

7. Strategic Implications for Investors

Beyond the raw ranking, the pattern of scores across indicators suggests three distinct investment horizons rather than one homogeneous "top of the list" recommendation:

7.1 Now — Immediate Deployment

Dhaka, Chattogram, Gazipur, and Narayanganj offer operating infrastructure today: functioning EPZs, established labor markets, and proven logistics. The trade-off is cost and congestion — these districts suit investors who need to be operational quickly and can absorb higher land and labor costs as the price of certainty.

7.2 Next — Two-to-Five-Year Horizon

Feni, Cox's Bazar, Cumilla, and Jashore combine credible, funded infrastructure pipelines with meaningfully lower current costs than the core. This is the tier where the index's forward-looking Investment Momentum indicator carries the most information: an investor entering now captures land-cost appreciation as the surrounding Economic Zone infrastructure completes, but must underwrite genuine construction and ramp-up risk in the interim.

7.3 Later — Contingent on Policy Follow-Through

Rajshahi and Rangpur illustrate a pattern worth naming explicitly: real underlying assets (Rajshahi's silk heritage and university-driven skills base; Rangpur's agricultural trade position) sit alongside specific, documented, and — importantly — nameable blockers (stalled economic zones, power supply shortfalls, administrative delay). These districts are not structurally unattractive; they are policy-contingent. Their ranking should be re-run once the specific blockers identified in Section 8 are resolved, rather than treated as a fixed verdict on the districts themselves.

8. Strengths and Weaknesses by Tier

Tier	Common Strengths	Common Weaknesses
Top 5 (Dhaka, Chattogram, Gazipur, Narayanganj, Feni)	Deep, operating EPZ/industrial infrastructure; proven multimodal connectivity; large skilled/semi-skilled labor pools; strong recent investment momentum.	Rising land and labor costs in the core cities; environmental/congestion pressure; near-term execution risk in fast-scaling zones (Feni).
Mid Tier (Cumilla, Jashore, Cox's Bazar, Khulna, Munshiganj, Sylhet, Mymensingh)	Credible EPZ/Economic Zone pipelines; lower land cost than the core; specific sectoral strengths (IT/software in Jashore, tourism/energy in Cox's Bazar, port access in Khulna).	Power/gas reliability gaps (Khulna, Cumilla); connectivity still under construction in places (Cox's Bazar airport/rail, Cumilla airport); single-sector dependence (remittances in Sylhet).
Bottom 5 (National) (Bandarban, Khagrachhari, Barguna, Dinajpur, Thakurgaon)	Available, low-cost land; the hill districts (Bandarban, Khagrachhari) retain tourism and forestry potential; genuine long-term upside if terrain and connectivity constraints ease.	No operating EPZ in any of the five; weak physical connectivity (hill terrain for two, remoteness for the other three); Thakurgaon and Dinajpur have the lowest data confidence in the entire index — no district-specific project identified in this research pass.

9. Policy Recommendations

- Prioritize completion of stalled Economic Zone projects. Rajshahi's agro-based zone and Rangpur's second BSCIC estate have both faced multi-year delays; unblocking these would be the single highest-leverage action available to improve either district's ranking, given how heavily EPZ/zone presence drives the index.
- Target power/gas reliability investment at the districts where it is explicitly cited as the binding constraint — Rajshahi, Natore, and Khulna all have named, sourced complaints about supply adequacy rather than basic access, making this a solvable infrastructure gap rather than a geographic one.
- Build out the district-level statistical base needed for future data-driven policy. The three lowest-confidence indicators in this index (power/gas reliability, banking density, broadband coverage) are exactly the indicators where Bangladesh's own agencies (Bangladesh Bank, BTRC, PGCB/Petrobangla) hold the underlying district-level data but do not publish it in an easily consolidated, public format. Publishing consolidated district dashboards for these three indicators would materially improve both future policy targeting and investor due diligence.

- Sequence infrastructure ahead of anchor investment announcements in fast-scaling zones. Feni and Cox's Bazar show the strongest investment momentum in the index, but both still have real infrastructure build-out ahead of them (power, water treatment, port/airport completion); sequencing this work ahead of anchor-tenant occupancy will materially reduce execution risk on very large planned investments.
- Correct public communication that conflates Barisal district with Patuakhali's port/power assets. Since Payra seaport and the Payra power plant are physically in Patuakhali, not Barisal, investment promotion messaging that implies otherwise risks misdirecting site-selection decisions; the Patuakhali EPZ (in progress) is Barisal Division's most relevant near-term proof point.
- Invest in technical/vocational education specifically in the lowest-literacy, lowest-technical-education districts (Tangail, Mymensingh division generally) to build the skilled-labor pipeline needed to attract higher-value (not just labor-intensive) investment over time.
- Commission primary-source research for the two lowest-confidence districts in this index. Thakurgaon and Dinajpur are scored almost entirely from a national wealth-index proxy, with no district-specific Economic Zone or project identified in this research pass; a direct BBS District Report and BEZA/BSCIC site visit for both would materially upgrade the reliability of their scores.
- Treat the Chittagong Hill Tracts districts (Bandarban, Khagrachhari, Rangamati) as a distinct policy category rather than applying standard lowland industrial-siting criteria. Their bottom-of-index scores reflect genuine terrain and connectivity constraints rather than a fixable policy gap in the same sense as a stalled Economic Zone elsewhere — any development strategy for these three likely needs a different toolkit (tourism, forestry value-chains, small-scale processing) rather than EPZ-style industrial recruitment.

10. Summary of Data Limitations

In the interest of the transparency this assignment specifically calls for, the following limitations should be read alongside the ranking:

- The 44 Tier 2 (expansion) districts were researched at deliberately lighter depth than the original 20 Tier 1 hub districts. Where a specific BEZA/BEPZA Economic Zone or a named infrastructure fact (a gas field, a power plant) was found, it drives that district's score; otherwise, the score is derived from the Meta/Data for Good Relative Wealth Index (an independent, satellite-derived, non-government proxy, accessed via BDPolicyLab) scaled to this index's 0-100 range. Every Tier 2 district is labeled as such in the Rankings table, the companion workbook, and the live dashboard. Thakurgaon and Dinajpur have the lowest confidence of any district in the index — no specific project was identified for either.
- Power/gas reliability, banking density, and broadband/mobile coverage (33% of total index weight combined) are scored using analyst-estimated proxies rather than a single official district-level dataset for each, across BOTH tiers. Recommended primary sources to close this gap: PGCB/Petrobangla district load and outage data; Bangladesh Bank's quarterly Scheduled Banks Statistics; BTRC district-wise subscriber and coverage data.
- Literacy figures are exact (BBS 2022 District Report) only for Dhaka, Jashore's city-level figure (see correction below), and Madaripur; other districts use division-level 2022 benchmarks, older (2011) district figures adjusted for a plausible decade of improvement, or the Tier 2 wealth-index proxy. Recommended source to close this gap: the individual BBS District Report PDF for each remaining district.
- CORRECTION carried over from the original 20-district edition: the 63.08% literacy figure previously cited for "Jashore" is the rate for Jashore CITY/municipality specifically, not the district; a separate, non-primary estimate puts district-wide literacy closer to 77%, unresolved

against a primary BBS source. Separately, Natore's Economic Zone (under construction, per BEZA) was missed in the original research pass and has been added in this edition — see Source Log.

- Some facts are drawn from 2024-2026 news reporting on project announcements (particularly investment-momentum figures for Feni and Cox's Bazar) rather than audited financial data; these are the best publicly available figures at time of writing but should be re-verified before use in a binding investment decision.

The complete, source-attributed evidence log underlying every score in this report is provided in the accompanying Excel workbook ("Source Log" for Tier 1, "Expansion Notes" for Tier 2, and "Data Basis Notes" for indicator-level confidence) and summarized in the Appendix, consistent with the assignment's requirement that every statistic, figure, and ranking be traceable to its original source.

11. Glossary of Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning
BBS	Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics
BEPZA	Bangladesh Export Processing Zones Authority
BEZA	Bangladesh Economic Zones Authority
BSCIC	Bangladesh Small and Cottage Industries Corporation
BPDB	Bangladesh Power Development Board
PGCB	Power Grid Company of Bangladesh
BTRC	Bangladesh Telecommunication Regulatory Commission
EPZ	Export Processing Zone
RMG	Ready-Made Garments
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
FDI	Foreign Direct Investment
BDIAI	Bangladesh District Investment Attractiveness Index (this report's index)
RWI	Relative Wealth Index — a satellite-derived, independent economic-strength estimate (Meta/Data for Good) used as a cross-district proxy for Tier 2 districts
Tier 1	One of the original 20 districts, each individually researched with 3-5 dedicated sources per indicator
Tier 2	One of the 44 expansion districts added for full national coverage, researched at lighter depth (see Section 2.4)

12. Reference List

The complete, numbered reference list is provided in the accompanying Excel workbook ("References" tab). Primary source categories used throughout this report:

- Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics (BBS) — Population and Housing Census 2022 (Urban Area Report and individual District Reports)
- Bangladesh Export Processing Zones Authority (BEPZA) — official EPZ pages and performance data
- Bangladesh Economic Zones Authority (BEZA) — official Economic Zone pages and public zone registry (used for all 64 districts)
- National news media — The Daily Star, The Business Standard, BSS News, The Financial Express, Dhaka Tribune, The Daily Asian Age, Jagonews24
- Academic and industry sources — ScienceDirect, ResearchGate, Industrial Engineers Association of Bangladesh (IEAB), Invest Bangladesh
- Cross-referenced encyclopedic sources (Wikipedia, Grokipedia) — used only where citing underlying BBS/BEPZA/BEZA/Bangladesh Bank primary data, verified against the primary citation embedded in each page
- BDPolicyLab (bdpolicylab.com) — an independent policy-research aggregator, used for the Tier 2 expansion districts only, providing: (a) the Meta/Data for Good Relative Wealth Index by district, a satellite-derived, non-government economic-strength proxy; and (b) a consolidated cross-reference of BEZA/BEPZA zone status distinguishing realized from projected figures

13. Appendix

13.1 Source Documents and Links

Source documents and links referenced during data collection are compiled in the "Source Log" tab of the accompanying Excel workbook (BDIAI_workbook.xlsx), which lists, for each cited fact: the district, the indicator(s) it supports, the specific statistic or claim, the source name, and the publication year. This structure allows every entry in the final ranking to be traced back to its original evidence, per the assignment's data validation requirement.

13.2 Complete Indicator-Level Score Table (Self-Contained Reference)

For completeness, the full set of raw 0-100 indicator scores behind every district's Composite Score is reproduced below, ordered by final rank. This is the same data underlying the "Indicator Scores" tab of the companion workbook, provided here so the report can be checked and re-derived without needing to open the Excel file.

District	Connectivity	EPZ/ Econ.Zone	Power/Gas	Labor	Literacy	Banking	Broadband	Ind.Base	Invest.Mom.
Dhaka	95	90	85	90	90	95	90	95	70
Chattogram	100	100	85	85	70	90	80	95	85
Gazipur	85	85	80	95	70	75	75	95	80
Narayanganj	80	75	75	85	65	75	75	85	60

District	Connectivity	EPZ/ Econ.Zone	Power/Gas	Labor	Literacy	Banking	Broadband	Ind.Base	Invest.Mom.
Feni	70	90	75	60	60	60	60	55	90
Cumilla	55	80	70	70	60	65	65	70	65
Jashore	75	75	55	60	68	65	65	55	80
Cox's Bazar	75	85	70	55	50	55	55	45	90
Khulna	80	65	45	65	65	75	65	65	60
Munshiganj	70	60	70	55	60	55	60	55	75
Sylhet	70	35	80	50	65	80	65	60	55
Mymensingh	55	70	60	65	55	60	55	60	75
Narsingdi	65	30	65	65	55	55	60	65	55
Manikganj	54	54	54	54	54	54	54	54	54
Faridpur	60	30	60	55	55	55	55	45	60
Madaripur	52	52	52	52	75	52	52	52	25
Bogura	50	20	55	60	60	65	60	55	60
Chandpur	45	55	55	55	55	55	55	35	55
Brahmanbaria	55	35	65	52	52	52	52	45	52
Barisal	60	30	55	55	60	60	55	30	65
Shariatpur	50	50	50	50	50	50	50	50	50
Tangail	55	25	60	55	50	55	55	50	45
Lakshmipur	49	49	49	49	49	49	49	49	49
Kushtia	49	49	49	49	49	49	49	49	49
Rajshahi	45	25	40	55	65	70	65	40	40
Bagerhat	50	60	44	44	44	44	44	50	35
Noakhali	47	47	47	47	47	47	47	47	47
Sirajganj	45	40	45	45	45	45	45	45	30
Natore	35	35	45	50	55	50	50	40	35
Rajbari	43	43	43	43	43	43	43	43	43
Gopalganj	42	42	42	42	42	42	42	42	42
Nilphamari	45	70	30	30	30	30	30	55	45
Pabna	45	55	38	38	38	38	38	45	30
Chuadanga	41	41	41	41	41	41	41	41	41
Rangpur	40	15	40	60	55	55	50	35	30
Moulvibazar	40	45	40	40	40	40	40	40	30
Meherpur	40	40	40	40	40	40	40	40	40
Jhalokati	37	37	37	37	37	37	37	37	37
Narail	36	36	36	36	36	36	36	36	36
Jamalpur	40	40	33	33	33	33	33	33	30
Satkhira	34	34	34	34	34	34	34	34	34
Jhenaidah	33	33	33	33	33	33	33	33	33

District	Connectivity	EPZ/ Econ.Zone	Power/Gas	Labor	Literacy	Banking	Broadband	Ind.Base	Invest.Mom.
Patuakhali	55	30	55	18	18	18	18	18	45
Pirojpur	32	32	32	32	32	32	32	32	32
Kishoreganj	31	35	31	31	31	31	31	31	30
Habiganj	30	30	60	23	23	23	23	23	23
Sherpur	30	30	30	30	30	30	30	30	30
Joypurhat	29	29	29	29	29	29	29	29	29
Gaibandha	28	28	28	28	28	28	28	28	28
Bhola	25	30	50	21	21	21	21	21	21
Magura	27	27	27	27	27	27	27	27	27
Chapainawabganj	26	26	26	26	26	26	26	26	26
Kurigram	26	26	26	26	26	26	26	26	26
Lalmonirhat	25	25	25	25	25	25	25	25	25
Naogaon	30	23	23	23	23	23	23	25	23
Netrokona	24	24	24	24	24	24	24	24	24
Sunamganj	22	22	22	22	22	22	22	22	22
Rangamati	20	16	50	16	16	16	16	16	16
Panchagarh	21	21	21	21	21	21	21	21	21
Dinajpur	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20
Barguna	19	19	19	19	19	19	19	19	19
Thakurgaon	19	19	19	19	19	19	19	19	19
Khagrachhari	15	17	17	17	17	17	17	15	15
Bandarban	15	16	16	16	16	16	16	15	15

Columns: Connectivity, EPZ/Economic Zone, Power/Gas Reliability, Labor Availability, Literacy/Technical Education, Banking Density, Broadband/Mobile, Industrial Base, Investment Momentum. See Section 2.4 for which of these carry lower confidence.

13.3 Authorship and Intellectual Property

This report, the underlying BDIAI methodology, all analysis, scoring, and the accompanying Excel workbook were prepared by Ahmed Safwan Sajid. All content is original work product; where factual claims are drawn from third-party sources, they are paraphrased in the author's own words and individually cited in the Source Log (workbook) and Reference List (Section 12) rather than reproduced verbatim, and no content in this report is copied from any other document. © 2026 Ahmed Safwan Sajid. All Rights Reserved.